Figure 7. Former market stalls in front of Virupaksha Temple

Elite women wear five yards long garments of white cotton or silk of bright colours. One part of it ‘is girt around them below, and the other part they throw over one shoulder and across their breasts in such a way that one arm and shoulder remain uncovered’. They wear ‘leather shoes well embroidered in silk, [and] necklaces, bracelets, nose and ear pieces of gold, precious stones, and fine coral beads’, with uncovered heads, hair held in a knot and scented flowers in it. From childhood they are taught to sing and dance. Barbosa describes a local ceremony in which, upon turning twelve, a girl ‘takes her own virginity’ with a stick.

The king has a large harem, for which ‘the fairest and most healthy women are sought throughout the kingdom’, after which they are materially secure for life. ‘They bathe daily in the many tanks’, and the ‘king goes to see them bathing, and she who pleases him most is sent for to come to his chamber’. Barbosa claims that ‘there is such envy and rivalry among these women with regard to the king’s favour, that “some kill others” and some poison themselves’.

When waging war, the king deploys the 100,000 warriors on his payroll, and also recruits 5000 to 6000 courtesans to go with them, claiming that ‘war cannot be waged where there are no women’. Barbosa adds that these women ‘are all unmarried, great musicians, dancers and acrobats, and very quick and nimble at their performances’.

Men of the warrior class eat all meats except beef and marry as many women as they can afford, who ‘when their husbands die . . . burn themselves alive with their corpses’, sometimes after ornate public rituals based on rank. ‘This abominable practice of burning is so customary, and is held in such honour among them, that when the King dies four or five hundred women burn themselves with him.’ Women who refuse are held ‘in great dishonour, and their kindred shave their heads and turn them away as disgraced and a shame to their families’. If young, they are sent to a temple ‘to earn money for the said temple with their bodies’.

Men of the priestly class do not eat meat, ‘marry only one wife’, and ‘hold the greatest liberties and privileges and are not liable to death for anything whatsoever which they do’ (Nuniz said this too). They get ‘much